JA
The Jiva Academy



Nurture

An Introductory Guide

2024 Edition

SUPPORTING DEVOTEE MENTAL WELLNESS

Compiled by:

The Jiva Academy

Consultants
Partha dasa (Grihastha Vision Team North America), Rambhoru devi dasi (Karuna Care Association, USA), Junica Ramsarooj (Clinical Psychologist RSA) & Dr John Yasenchak (Bhakti Recovery Group)

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Graphic Design
Sivananda Sena dasa

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The Jiva Academy is alone responsible for the views expressed in this guide. These views do not necessarily represent the views and policies of the institutions to which the Academy is affiliated.

From the desk of the Jiva Academy
We offer our respectful obeisances to ISKCON's founder-acharya, His Divine Grace A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada, whose service is our life and soul. He has blessed the entire globe with the transcendental knowledge of Krishna Consciousness. This knowledge is a worthy shelter for all who seek solace in times of distress.

Dedication
This Ebook is dedicated to all who serve the Vaishnavas.

CONTENTS

1. Welcome & Introduction
2. Mental Health
3. Mental Distress
4. Mental Illness
5. Mental Distress vs Mental illness
6. Barriers to Mental Health Support
7. Why Mental Wellbeing Matters to Devotees
8. Moving towards a Cure
9. A Guiding Principle
10. What does it mean to Manage one's Mental Wellbeing
11. Confidentiality - Re-imaging the Art of Love
12. How to Balance Spiritual & Material Life
13. Balance – A Paradigm Shift
14. An Assessment of Mental Health in ISKCON
15. Signs and symptoms of Mental Distress
16. Responding to a Devotee in Mental Distress
17. Dealing with Perceived Mental illness
18. Depression
19. Anxiety Disorders
20. Addictions
21. Grief
22. Knowledge of ACE's
23. Mental Health in times of Social Upheaval
24. Helplines
25. Closing - Words for your reflection
26. Addendum A
29. References

"To those who are constantly devoted and worship Me with love, I give the understanding by which they can come to Me."

Bhagavad Gita, Chapter 10,Text 10



Welcome And Introduction

Welcome to “Nurture”. The purpose of this eBook is to raise mental health awareness among ISKCON devotees and communities.

This eBook may help you understand the difference between mental distress and mental illness, how holding on to unhealthy beliefs can hurt your mental health, and how to take a responsible approach towards mental wellness.



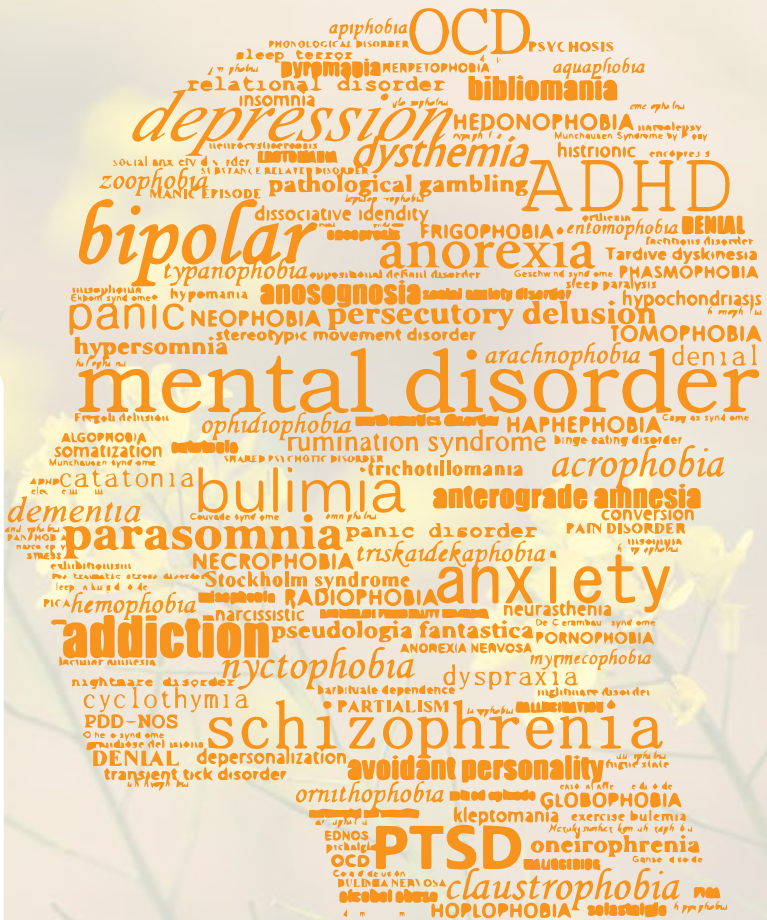
> This guide is for information purposes only. It is not a substitute for professional medical advice. Please consult a health professional for medical advice. In this guide the terms mental wellness, mental wellbeing and mental health are used interchangeably. These terms are different from the term mental illness. Anonymous case studies are referenced to make concepts relatable.



MENTAL HEALTH

Mental health is a state of well-being in which an individual realizes his or her own abilities, can cope with the normal stresses of life, can work productively and is able to make a contribution to his or her community. Mental health is fundamental to our collective and individual ability as humans to think, emote, interact with each other, earn a living and enjoy life. On this basis, the promotion, protection and restoration of mental health can be regarded as a vital concern of individuals, communities and societies throughout the world. [-1]

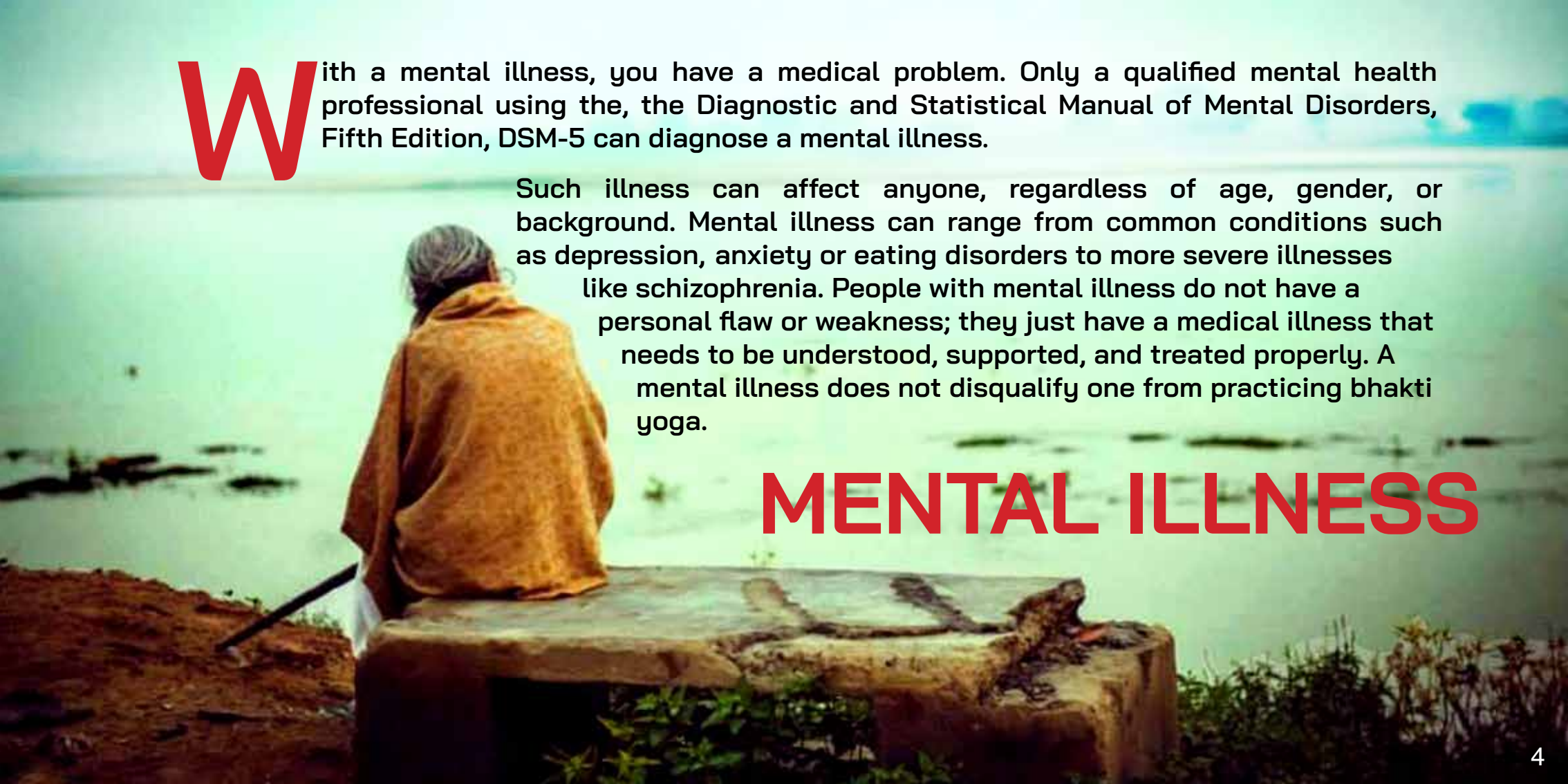
World Health Organisation



MENTAL DISTRESS

The American Psychiatric Association defines mental distress as "a set of painful mental and physical symptoms that are associated with normal fluctuations of mood in most people." [-2]

As a person, we can expect to feel a lot of different emotions. It's okay to feel sad, anxious, or angry sometimes. It is normal to experience intense negative emotions from time to time. As we go about our daily lives, our moods can sometimes be so intense that they cause us mental and physical pain. We may call this mental distress. Strong emotions, although at times overwhelming, indicate that we are alive and capable of connecting deeply with others. Mental distress that lasts only a few days (or perhaps a week or so) is a natural and normal part of life. We're ok!



MENTAL ILLNESS

With a mental illness, you have a medical problem. Only a qualified mental health professional using the, the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, Fifth Edition, DSM-5 can diagnose a mental illness.

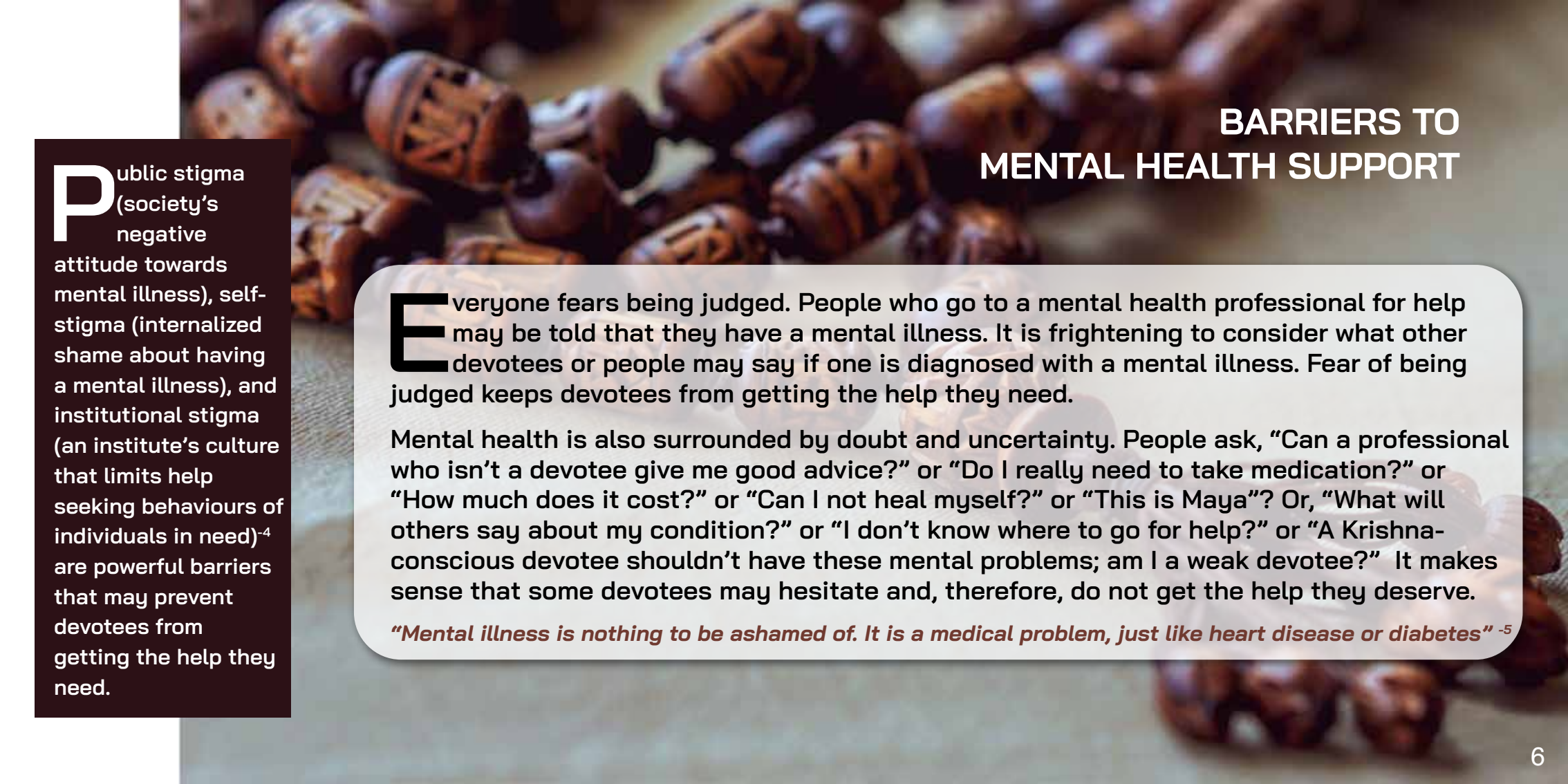
Such illness can affect anyone, regardless of age, gender, or background. Mental illness can range from common conditions such as depression, anxiety or eating disorders to more severe illnesses like schizophrenia. People with mental illness do not have a personal flaw or weakness; they just have a medical illness that needs to be understood, supported, and treated properly. A mental illness does not disqualify one from practicing bhakti yoga.

Mental Distress vs Mental illness

Mental distress is normal, but having a mental illness is not normal. Life's problems can cause stress, worry, or sadness. This is normal. But prolonged feelings of distress that make it difficult to function normally may indicate a more serious issue. It is important to get medical help for a mental illness.

Mental illnesses are not the result of being weak or having bad character. They are real medical problems that need to be treated and helped with the right care.

Helping others understand how challenging mental illnesses can be is an important way to promote empathy and reduce the shame surrounding mental health.



BARRIERS TO MENTAL HEALTH SUPPORT

Public stigma (society's negative attitude towards mental illness), self-stigma (internalized shame about having a mental illness), and institutional stigma (an institute's culture that limits help seeking behaviours of individuals in need)[-4] are powerful barriers that may prevent devotees from getting the help they need.

Everyone fears being judged. People who go to a mental health professional for help may be told that they have a mental illness. It is frightening to consider what other devotees or people may say if one is diagnosed with a mental illness. Fear of being judged keeps devotees from getting the help they need.

Mental health is also surrounded by doubt and uncertainty. People ask, "Can a professional who isn't a devotee give me good advice?" or "Do I really need to take medication?" or "How much does it cost?" or "Can I not heal myself?" or "This is Maya"? Or, "What will others say about my condition?" or "I don't know where to go for help?" or "A Krishna-conscious devotee shouldn't have these mental problems; am I a weak devotee?" It makes sense that some devotees may hesitate and, therefore, do not get the help they deserve.

"Mental illness is nothing to be ashamed of. It is a medical problem, just like heart disease or diabetes" [-5]

All devotees are vulnerable to physical and mental ailments. [-6] Mental health professionals in ISKCON say that devotees have the same mental health problems as everyone else. One in eight people in the world has a mental illness. [-7] It's possible that there are more cases of stress, depression, insomnia and psychotic illness among devotees than among the general population. [-8] Although poor mental wellness can interrupt devotional service, devotees often overlook their mental wellness.

Is there a treasure greater than the mercy of the Lord ? In this troubled world, every devotee is like a living channel of Lord Caitanya Mahaprabhu's mercy.[-10] Because of this, a devotee may be regarded as someone very special. Therefore, a devotees health is important and needs to be carefully guarded. Devotees are precious. Their mental wellbeing matters.

"The highest goal of life can be achieved as long as one's body is stout and strong. We should therefore live in such a way that we keep ourselves always healthy and strong in mind and intelligence so that we can distinguish the goal of life from a life full of problems."

[Srimad Bhagavatam, Canto 7, Chapter 6, Text 5]



Why mental wellbeing matters for devotees



Moving towards a Cure



While devotional service is the cure,[-11] poor mental health may make it difficult to practice devotional service. Therefore, caring for one's mental health is worthwhile. To help improve a devotee's mental health (like this eBook for example), it might be necessary to use questionable theories and methods from modern psychology and medicine. Some people may disagree with using ever-changing scientific theories. This approach, however, does not contradict the culture of the Srimad Bhagavatam, which promotes the use of all disciplines of knowledge in the service of the Lord. [-12]

If a devotee requires professional medical attention to be fit for serving Krishna, then it is only practical they should get it.

A Guiding Principle

Health care is something that each person chooses to do for themselves. Everybody makes different choices. Going with the right choice every time is not easy. This is especially true now that we can get a lot of information and often have different opinions based on that information. Every person has the right to define their choices, difficulties, or experiences in ways that makes sense to them.

To be the best person we can be for Srila Prabhupada and other Vaishnavas, we should make choices that are good for our health. This important sastric principle should guide individual choices and personal development:- accept what is favourable for one's development in Krishna conscious and avoid what is unfavourable.

Note: According to the World Health Organization, setting standards and definitions for what is "normal" mental health across different cultures and communities is not a good idea.





WHAT DOES IT MEAN TO MANAGE ONES **MENTAL WELLBEING?**

Taking care of your mental health is not a different skill. It's a part of taking care of yourself and your health. A healthy daily routine, cleanliness, a healthy diet, exercise, plenty of sleep, self-awareness (especially in regards to one's emotions and limitations), finding inspired purpose, healthy relationships, helping others, recreation, meditation, reaching out for support as soon as the need arises, and connecting to resources that are favourable for one's health are some of the things that may help us manage our mental health better. In many ways, this fits perfectly with Vaishnava culture.

Yet, devotees often disregard their own personal care (diet, sleep, exercise, medicine, etc.) in favour of assisting others or the mission. [-14] Please be cautious; making poor choices on a regular basis may put a devotee in danger of illness, burnout, loneliness, depression or anxiety.

A point to consider: According to the American Psychiatric Association, burnout is an individuals response to a systemic problem. Therefore, preventing burnout is as much the responsibility of the organization as it is of the individual.

Confidentiality – Reimagining the Art of Love

In times of difficulty, here is a helpful healing tool: Find someone who will listen to you without imposing their own ideas about how you should feel or think; find someone who is willing to listen to the feelings behind your words without judging you. Find someone you can talk with! In other words, listening to someone in confidence is a key step in enhancing their mental health. The counselling profession, for instance, places great importance on confidentiality to ensure that therapy is effective.



ISKCON is better positioned to develop a culture of love and trust thanks to the blessings of Srila Rupa Goswami and his offering of the six loving exchanges.[15] The feeling of being loved and wanted without being judged is a powerful feeling. One-third of the loving exchanges in ISKCON involve sharing one's mind in confidence and honouring what has been shared in confidence.

We have much work to do here.
Let us practice improving our levels of confidentiality.
It starts with each one of us, today. And tomorrow – we improve our practice.



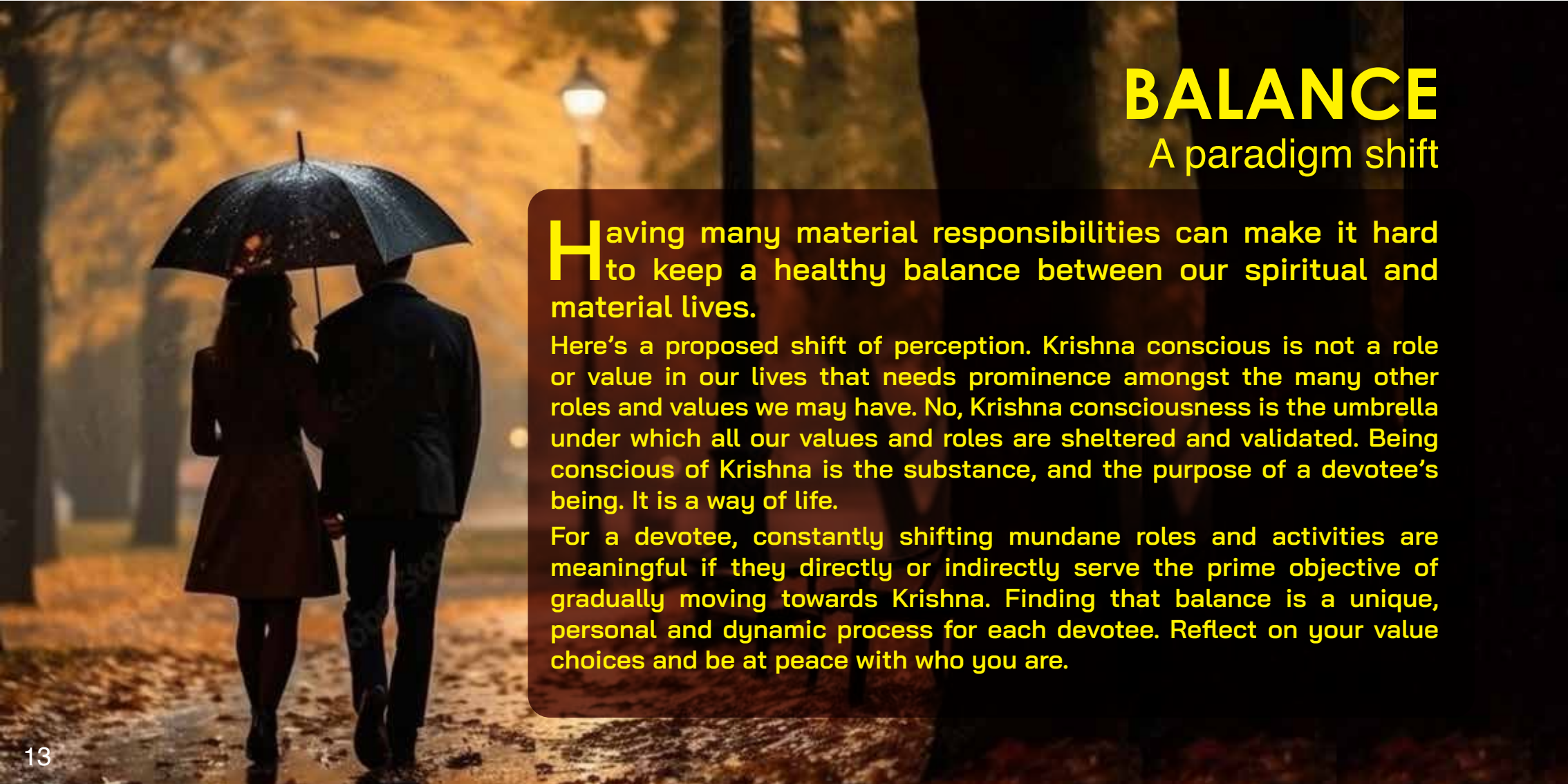
HOW TO BALANCE SPIRITUAL LIFE AND MATERIAL LIFE

We should never underestimate the power of the holy name [16]. We should also not underestimate the powerful influence of association with the Lord's devotees, discussions on Srimad Bhagavatam, Deity worship, or the influence of sacred places such as holy dhamas or temples. Yet, life is full of surprises, making it difficult to find balance[17]. Finding the balance between spiritual and material life can be difficult.

Here's a simple exercise modified from the Grihastha Vision Team's (GVT's) Grihastha Course to help you discover balance. Fill the pyramid on the right with your top ten values from the list of values provided below. More important values should be higher up on the pyramid with the highest-ranking value at the top.

a. Health
b. Preaching
c. Family
d. Safety
e. Wealth
f. Travel
g. Recreation
h. Sadhana
i. Temple Service
j. Education
k. Career
l. Social Life
m. Children
n. Peace
o. Balanced lifestyle
p. Krishna Consciousness





BALANCE

A paradigm shift

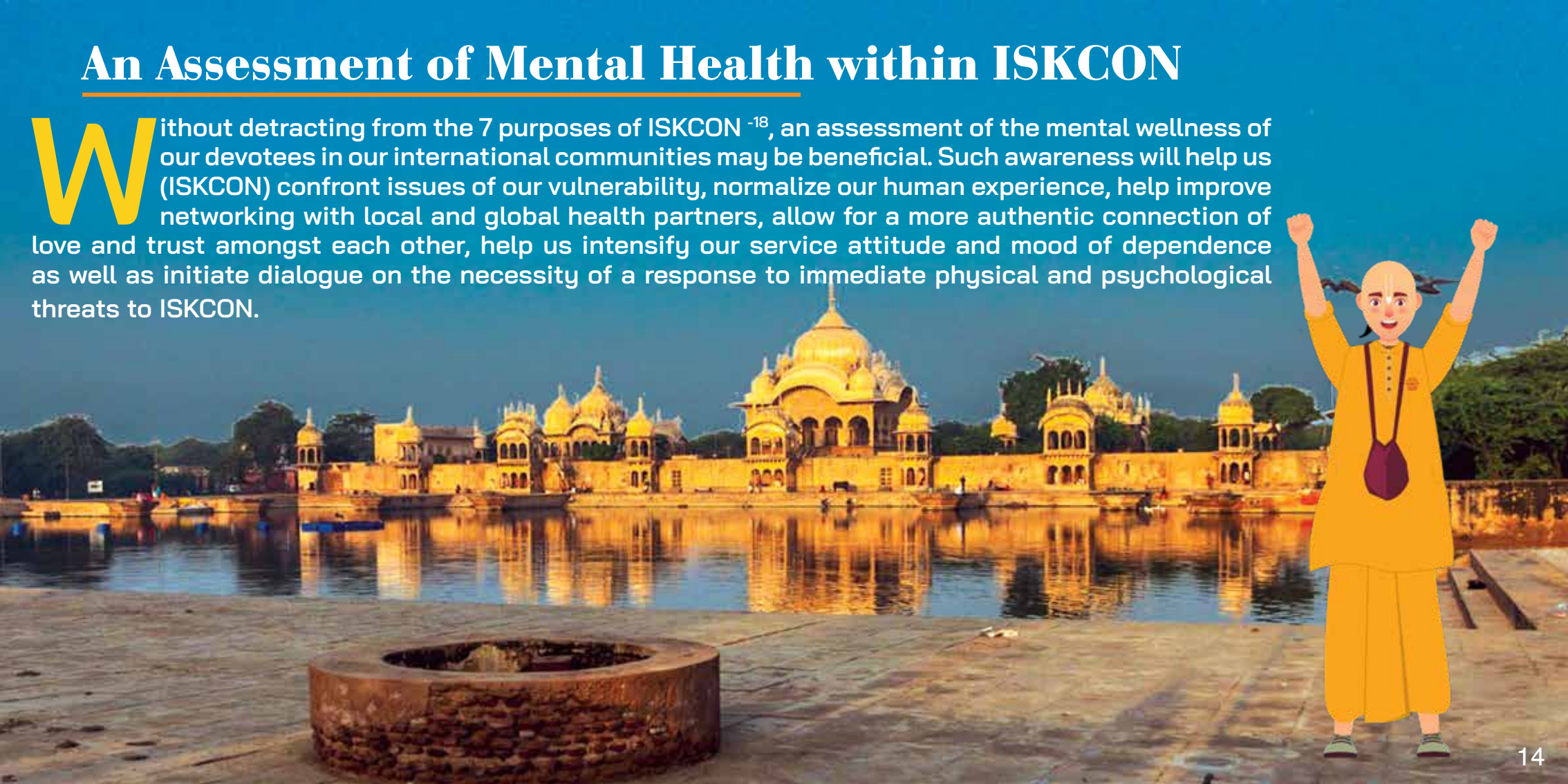
Having many material responsibilities can make it hard to keep a healthy balance between our spiritual and material lives.

Here's a proposed shift of perception. Krishna conscious is not a role or value in our lives that needs prominence amongst the many other roles and values we may have. No, Krishna consciousness is the umbrella under which all our values and roles are sheltered and validated. Being conscious of Krishna is the substance, and the purpose of a devotee's being. It is a way of life.

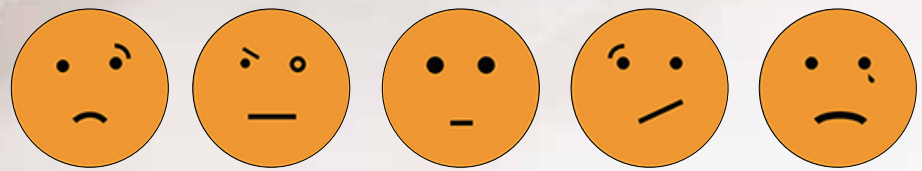
For a devotee, constantly shifting mundane roles and activities are meaningful if they directly or indirectly serve the prime objective of gradually moving towards Krishna. Finding that balance is a unique, personal and dynamic process for each devotee. Reflect on your value choices and be at peace with who you are.

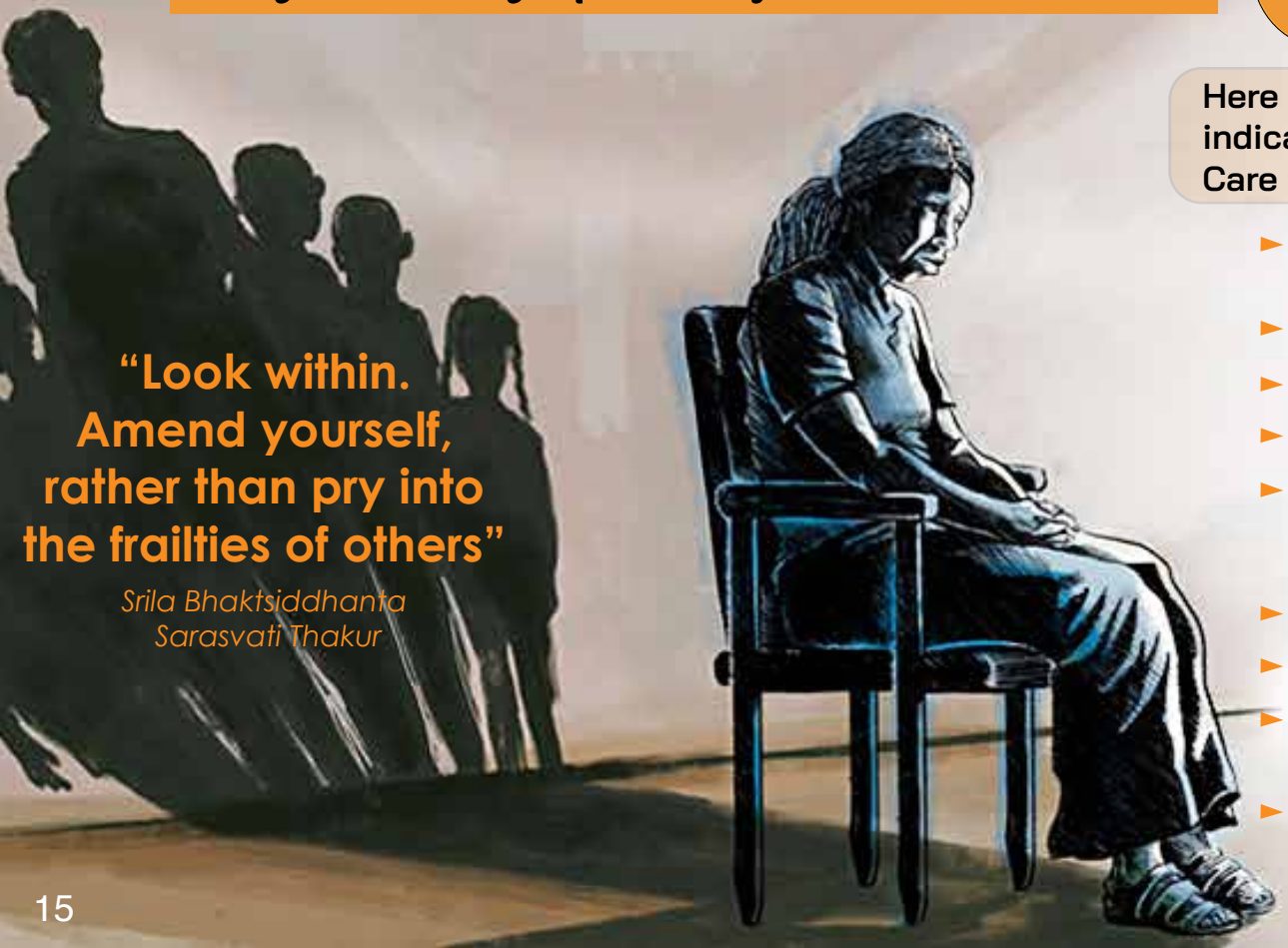
An Assessment of Mental Health within ISKCON

Without detracting from the 7 purposes of ISKCON [-18], an assessment of the mental wellness of our devotees in our international communities may be beneficial. Such awareness will help us (ISKCON) confront issues of our vulnerability, normalize our human experience, help improve networking with local and global health partners, allow for a more authentic connection of love and trust amongst each other, help us intensify our service attitude and mood of dependence as well as initiate dialogue on the necessity of a response to immediate physical and psychological threats to ISKCON.



Signs and Symptoms of Mental Distress





"Look within. Amend yourself, rather than pry into the frailties of others"

Srila Bhaktsiddhanta Sarasvati Thakur

Here is a self-assessment. A "yes" response for a question indicates an area of potential risk. Contact your local Devotee Care team for queries or support.

- Have you lost interest in devotional activities you used to enjoy?
- Do you dread social events (work/family/devotees)?
- Is your anxiety affecting your concentration?
- Do you wish you were dead?
- Are you struggling to cope with daily activities because you feel too tired or are you unnaturally excited with too much energy?
- Do you feel trapped with no escape?
- Do you feel helpless and frequently cry?
- Do you find that there is no release for your pent-up anger or rage?
- Do your coping strategies include substance use, binge eating, risky behaviour or violent outbursts?



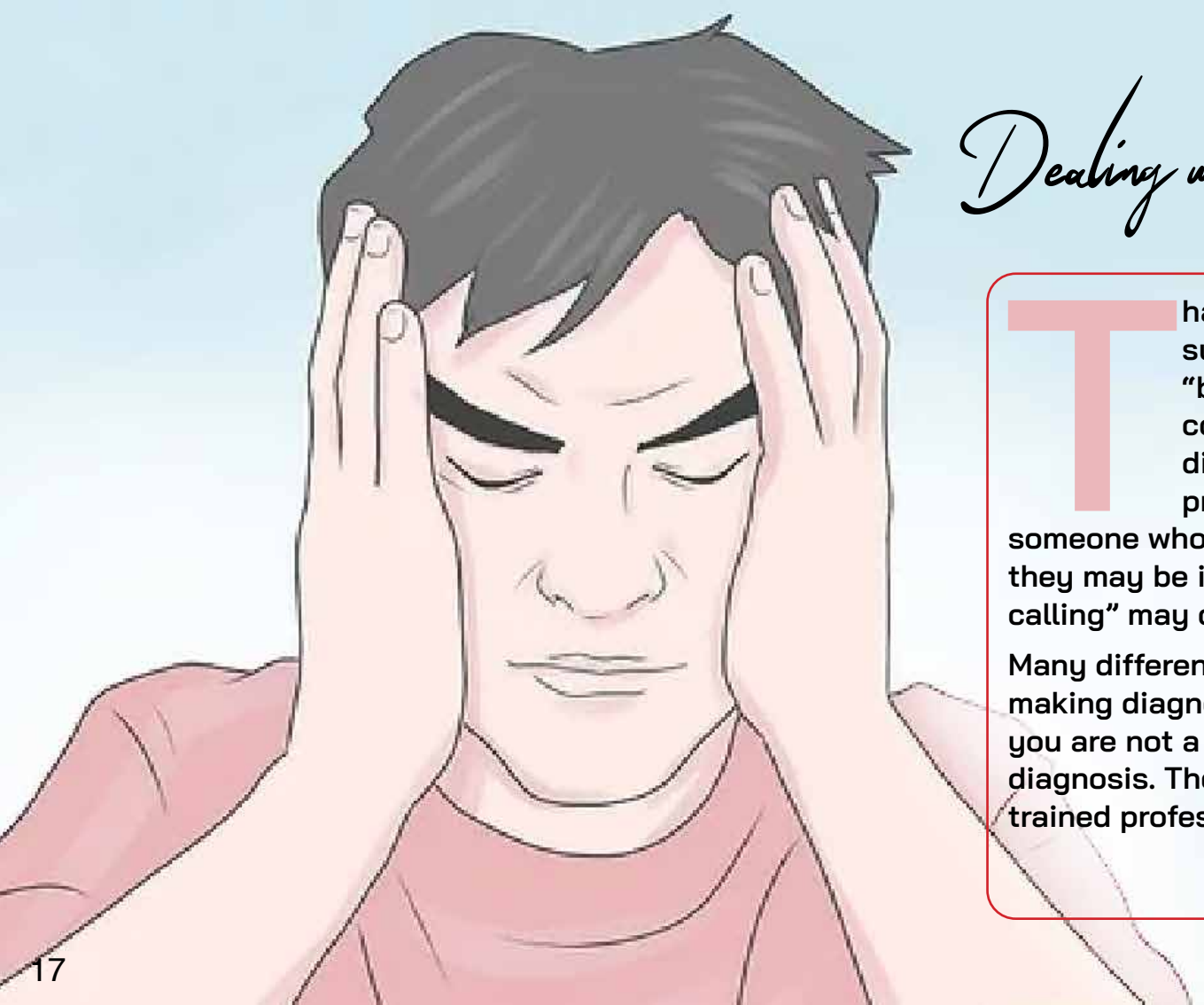
RESPONDING TO A DEVOTEE IN MENTAL DISTRESS

When a devotee is in mental distress, we should react based on what that devotee needs and how bad their distress is. Severe distress always requires professional intervention. Severe distress is indicated by a significant deterioration in functioning or the intent of self-harm or harm to others.

When the distress is painful but the devotee is able to function despite the difficulties, providing a safe space where the devotee may be heard and understood will be helpful. Support groups, counselling, or both could be beneficial at this time.

Responding to a devotee in mental distress is both an individual and institutional responsibility. While devotees are kind and caring, it is idealistic to expect all devotees to be skilled in offering emotional support and care as a natural by-product of their practice of devotional service. Attending to a devotee in distress requires skill that is developed with practice, intention and the necessary training.

Please contact your local Devotee Care Team for a list of useful service providers.



Dealing with Perceived Mental illness

Thanks to the availability of expert opinion, terms such as “hyperactive,” “OCD,” “depression,” “bipolar,” and “narcissist” are frequently used within communities and families. Our goal in making a diagnosis is to help those in need. Identifying the problem is the first step in fixing it. However, when someone who is not trained attempts to identify the problem, they may be incorrect. Instead of helping someone this “name-calling” may cause more harm.

Many different mental illnesses share common symptoms making diagnosis difficult even for trained professionals. If you are not a qualified health professional, never attempt a diagnosis. The recommended process is to always refer to a trained professional.



Depression

People often think that depression is a sign of mental weakness and that all you have to do to get better is "snap out of it." It is believed by some cultures that depression is a Western invention. Others think depression is caused by witchcraft. [19] Devotees may feel depression can be managed through philosophy and the holy name.[20] However, the experience of a broken leg, illness, or depression is generally not something that the holy name automatically removes. We still need to live through these experiences.

In the field of medicine, there are precise and widely accepted standards for diagnosing depression. Depression is a real, serious medical condition. The effects of depression can be devasting. No two devotees will be affected in the same way. Treatment usually involves counselling or medication or both but there is no "one-size-fits-all" for treatment. [21]

Depression puts one at high risk for developing other medical conditions (like heart disease, diabetes or stroke). Conversely, people with poor health are prone to depression. Anecdotal evidence points to depression as common among devotees. Devotees are encouraged to speak to their local Devotee Care Team or seek professional help if they feel depressed You are not alone..

Anxiety Disorder

Anxiety is apprehension about something that has not yet happened. Anxiety disorders are the most common mental illness, and 75% of people who have them are also likely to have another mental illness.[22] Do not disregard problems associated with anxiety. If you find that your anxiety is having an effect on your health and quality of life, get professional help.



A devotee's anxiety will be revealed by specific phobias or perhaps an episode of a panic attack. Here's a case of a devotee who pushed themself to perform a difficult service for many years. Constant anxiety and pent-up emotions caused the devotee to eventually have a breakdown when visiting a shopping mall. The devotee could not move or breath and felt as if having a heart attack. The devotee was later diagnosed with agoraphobia. What to speak of fear of public places, the devotee was unable to properly function when visiting the temple to perform their service. Treating phobias usually involves gradually exposing a person to face their phobia. Cognitive Behavioural Therapy is useful in treating anxiety. Medication may sometimes be prescribed.

Here is another reality - "Whenever pure topics of the transcendental world are discussed, the members of the audience forget all kinds of material hankerings, at least for the time being. Not only that, but they are no longer envious of one another, nor do they suffer from anxiety or fear."
[SB 4.30.35]



A person may hide their deep pain behind addictions.



Addiction is a strong and habitual want that significantly reduces control and leads to significant harm. [-22] **Drug and alcohol addictions are well known.**

Here are other addictions: gambling, sex, shopping, gaming, pornography and being a workaholic. [-23] **The World Health Organisation has classified gambling addiction as a disease.**

From what ISKCON devotee counsellors and health professionals have said, it sounds like addiction is common in ISKCON communities. It is tough dealing with addictions. Some addictions may be hereditary. And if that is not challenging enough, the global economy thrives on promoting various addictions. [-24]

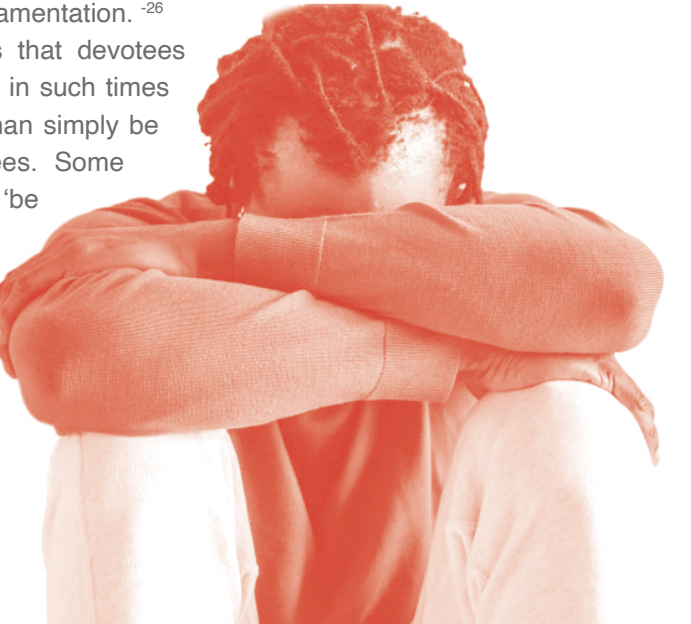
Here are some words of encouragement from Dr John Yasenchak of the Bhakti Recovery Group: “There are devotees around the world who are both struggling with or recovering from addictions. The number, of course, is difficult to know. Many are reluctant to come forward for many different reasons. Sometimes, it is difficult to ask for help in devotee communities. The Bhakti Recovery Group is an online fellowship of support for devotees in recovery and also for those who are struggling.
It combines the principles of Bhakti and the 12-step movement.”

Click here for more information
https://www.bhaktirecoverygroup.com/

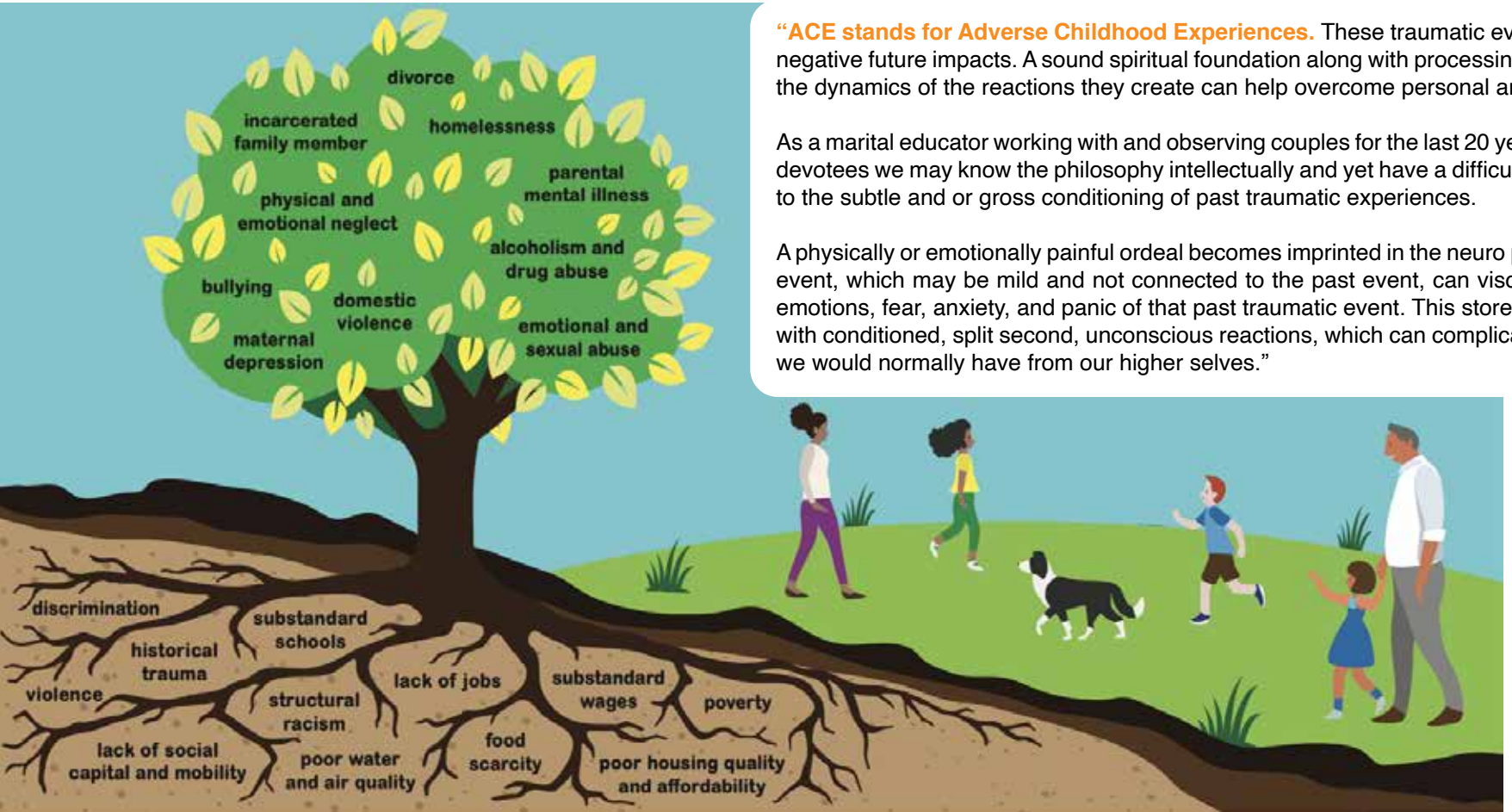


Grief is the normal human response to loss. Loss may include the loss of a loved one, losing a job, losing one's good health, divorce, a miscarriage etc. Grief is as unique to each person as their fingerprint. There is no right or wrong way to grieve. However, improperly processed grief is known to lead to common physical and mental ailments (like headaches, body pains, fatigue and addictions).

While sastra is the immovable rock on which devotees stand, it is an unhealthy practice to assume that, with the perfect philosophy, every devotee should be strong in the face of grief - "Those who are wise lament neither for the living nor for the dead." It is a misunderstanding that a devotee should be unfeeling [-25] or should not be overwhelmed by lamentation. [-26] Perhaps times of grief are times that devotees need each other the most. Mostly, in such times one need not do anything more than simply be present with the grieving devotees. Some grieving devotees may want to 'be preached to' at this time. Each devotee's experience of grief should be allowed to take its own course. **For devotees struggling with grief, being present without judgment may be more useful to the grieving devotee than any words we may say.**



KNOWLEDGE OF ACE'S CAN ASSIST YOU AND HELP SUPPORT OTHERS

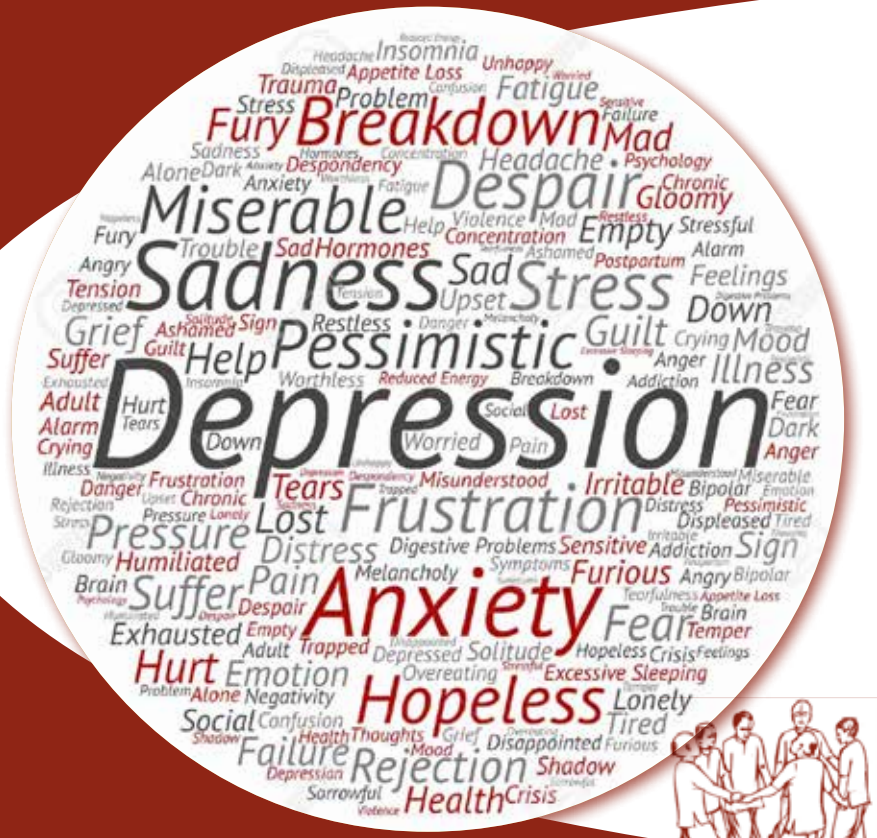


"ACE stands for Adverse Childhood Experiences. These traumatic events create impressions that can cause negative future impacts. A sound spiritual foundation along with processing these experiences and understanding the dynamics of the reactions they create can help overcome personal and relational problems.

As a marital educator working with and observing couples for the last 20 years, it is often apparent, that as aspiring devotees we may know the philosophy intellectually and yet have a difficult time applying it in our practical life due to the subtle and or gross conditioning of past traumatic experiences.

A physically or emotionally painful ordeal becomes imprinted in the neuro pathways of the brain. Years later, some event, which may be mild and not connected to the past event, can viscerally trigger the memory, smell, taste, emotions, fear, anxiety, and panic of that past traumatic event. This stored recollection can induce us to respond with conditioned, split second, unconscious reactions, which can complicate life. They are not the responses that we would normally have from our higher selves."

Read the full article by Partha dasa of the Grihastha Vision Team in Addendum A



— MENTAL HEALTH —

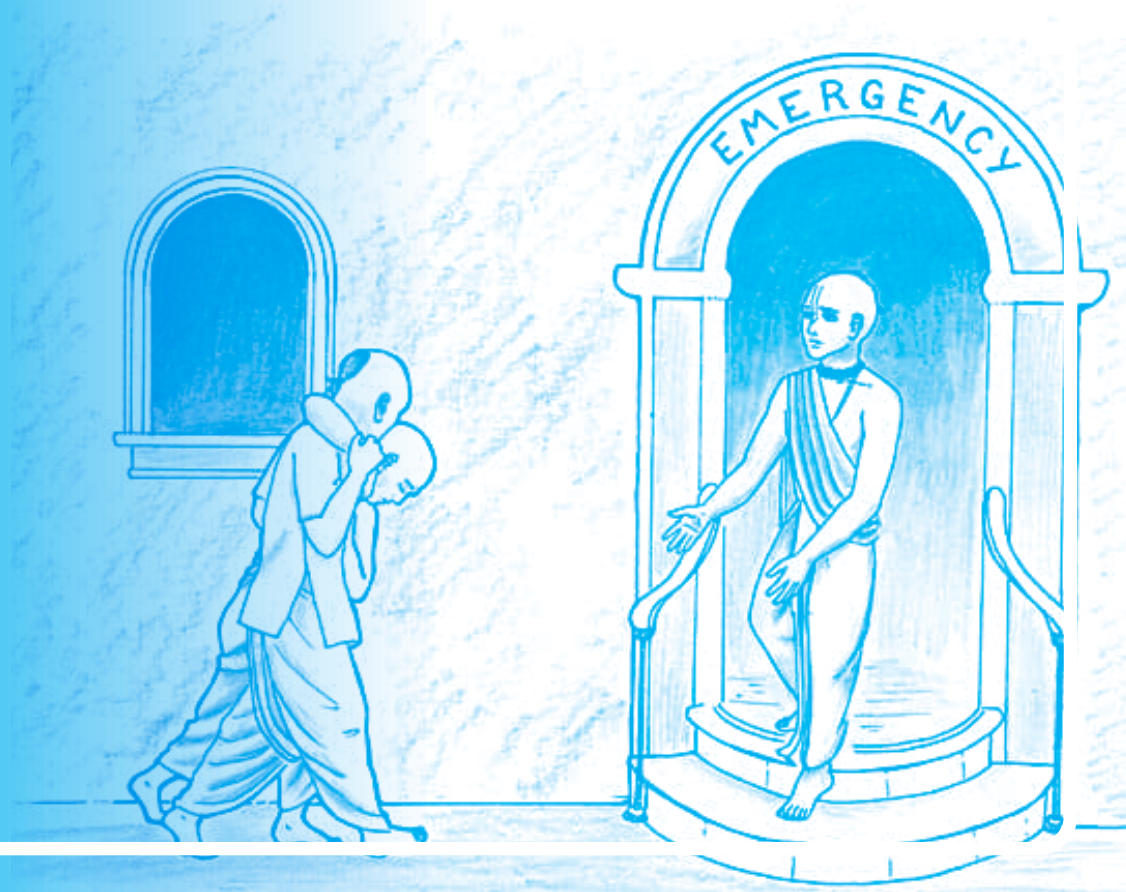
IN TIMES OF SOCIAL UPHEAVAL

War, unrest, political violence, riots, protests, floods, raging wildfires and perhaps a global pandemic may be a cause of collective social trauma. The effects of such events have a tremendous impact on ones mental health, even if one is merely an observer of such events on the news or social media. Here are some tips that may be helpful in times of social upheaval.

* Do not panic. It will be helpful to name and acknowledge your feelings. It is ok to feel anxious, nervous, uncertain and fearful. An experience of trauma is our bodies natural response to something abnormal.
* Seek help! Devotees should not be apathetic to their safety or self-preservation. Make an effort to lawfully protect yourself and others.
* Be mindful that each person will respond differently to the distress. Do not demand of yourself that which is beyond your ability.
* Focus on the holy name, kirtan, the company of devotees, prasad and scripture. Having a daily routine will be helpful. For those in a state of panic, breathing exercises are recommended.
* For oneself, with the help of scripture, cast away fear. Focus on all the positives in the situation. With this internal attitude see how you could assist others in their time of distress.
* Use social media with caution. Be selective of what media content you expose yourself to. It helps to minimize social media use. Be cautious of what images or words you use on all social media platforms. Do not create panic with misinformation. Share what is verifiable, useful and what helps the situation.



Many countries, regardless of the state of their mental health system, offer the incredible facility of helplines. Helplines are particularly useful in dealing with a wide variety of mental health issues. Think of important topics like suicide, domestic violence, low self-esteem, burnout, gender-based violence and loneliness that we have not discussed yet. If Helplines are available, devotees are encouraged to take advantage of this facility, without hesitation. They are low cost, easy to access and provide an immediate connection to a fellow human being who is a trained and unbiased professional.



Closing

We need to be reminded that we each matter to the Lord personally. In particular, it is Lord Caitanya Mahaprabhu's limitless compassion for us that motivates His great sankirtana mission.

Śrīla Narottama dāsa Ṭhākura sings, *patita-pāvana-hetu tava avatāra:* "O my Lord, You have appeared just to deliver all the fallen souls."

Here are some final words of summary for your reflection:

"Please accept my blessings. I beg to acknowledge receipt of your letter dated 9 February, 1969, and I have carefully noted the contents.

Regarding Syama Dasi's health, it is to be understood that so long we have got this material body there must be some trouble. Actually, medicine is not the remedial measures for our bodily troubles unless we are helped by Krishna. Therefore, whenever there is bodily trouble, we may adopt the prescribed methods of medical science and depend upon Krishna for His mercy. The best remedy, not only for Syama Dasi but for everyone, is to consult some approved physician. But ultimately, we have to depend on the Mercy of Krishna, so we should chant regularly, pray to Krishna to give us a chance to serve Him, and, if required, we may adopt the approved method of treatment."

Srila Prabhupada Letter Los Angeles 69-02-14



Addendum A

Knowledge of ACEs Can Assist You and Help Support Others
AUGUST 7, 2022 BY PARTHA DASA

A dirty car pulled up to the curb beside me as I was walking to my 5th grade school. Through a waft of cigarette smoke, a scruffy, bearded face enticed me to come in the car. I took off like lightening in the opposite direction. Even today, when seeing an unkempt beard on a stranger, I feel unsettled. I was fortunate to dodge a huge ACE that day.

ACE stands for Adverse Childhood Experiences. These traumatic events create impressions that can cause negative future impacts. A sound spiritual foundation along with processing these experiences and understanding the dynamics of the reactions they create can help overcome personal and relational problems.

As a marital educator working with and observing couples for the last 20 years, it is often apparent, that as aspiring devotees we may know the philosophy intellectually and yet have a difficult time applying it in our practical life due to the subtle and or gross conditioning of past traumatic experiences.

A physically or emotionally painful ordeal becomes imprinted in the neuro pathways of the brain. Years later, some event, which may be mild and not connected to the past event, can viscerally trigger the memory, smell, taste, emotions, fear, anxiety, and panic of that past traumatic event. This stored recollection can induce us to respond with conditioned, split second, unconscious reactions, which can complicate life. They are not the responses that we would normally have from our higher selves.
Let me illustrate this with a few examples of trauma induced interactions (names have been changed and the situations may be compilations of various cases). They illustrate the nature of reactive responses, which drag us towards the modes of passion and ignorance.

Gita dasi and Ram dasa had been married for 30 years and had gradually developed a repeating conflict. He would often come home from work, walk in the kitchen and ask his wife what she was doing- which over time became an annoyance. She would be cooking and snap, “What kind of stupid question is that? What does it look like I’m doing? I’m cooking!” He would sometimes withdraw and sometimes get angry. The rest of those evenings were disconnected and strained. After some relationship education, Gita dasi replied to Rama dasa’s usual question of “What are you doing?” with her feelings and not a criticism. “When you repeatedly come in the kitchen and ask about

something that seems rather obvious to me, I get a bit annoyed and frustrated." Instead of becoming defensive, he acknowledged her irritation and asked if they could have a discussion after dinner about this habitual exchange. Sitting down later, using reflective listening, or in Vaishnava terminology, revealing one's mind in confidence and hearing in confidence, (guhyam ākhyāti pṛcchati) he was able to realize on a deeper level what was driving his behavior. As a child he was often left alone for long periods, resulting in him feeing abandoned and unloved. The experience created an anxious need to feel a secure connection, which resulted in that ongoing query when entering the kitchen. She realized his actions were a bid for a loving, secure connection. With this mutual understanding, their dynamic changed. Instead of reacting negatively she began to respond with a hug, and some kind words. A little open, heart to heart communication corrected the disconnecting pattern which had its origin in adverse childhood experiences.

Let's look at what happens in more serious trauma.
Sita dasi, as a toddler, was punished by being placed on top of a high fridge in the kitchen, alone, which left her terrified. One day her husband texts that he will be late to pick her up. She becomes triggered, feels the same visceral feeling of abandonment, fear and panic of her childhood, and becomes angry and extremely hurt by her husband's message. Her husband is bewildered by her reaction to what appears to be a minor situation. Through therapy, Sita was able to process the past tragic abusive events and separate the past from the present. She can literally comfort her child of the past in current situations and then express her needs and feelings in a manner her husband is able to receive and understand. She can now respond in the mode of goodness, and he can compassionately reply with sensitivity and an awareness of how Sita can be triggered in certain situations.

Let's look at the result of even more severe trauma.
As a child, Atma dasa was emotionally abused, being constantly ridiculed, blamed, threatened and sometimes beaten. In his home atmosphere, he felt like he was constantly walking on thin ice. This resulted in a very low sense of self-esteem and a deep feeling of inadequacy. He compensated for this as an adult, by becoming an obsessive hard-working achiever, although any criticism would scrape his painful childhood scars and he would respond with the rage modeled by his childhood care givers. This became very problematic in his marriage. If his wife expressed the smallest doubt or correction, he would explode into extreme anger and eventually even physical violence. He had never processed the deep scars of his past. The smallest sense of criticism would rub open those childhood wounds, and he would respond in the only way he knew, with extreme anger, which, in turn, produced a surge of adrenaline, numbing the pain of his feelings of inadequacy and giving him a sense of power and control. He had become an anger junkie repeating the intergenerational cycle of abuse and was displaying an absolute failure of compassion.
Many other types of traumas may also have an impact, such as natural disasters and community violence.

If you have experienced one or more of these (ACE test) and are experiencing repeated relationship problems, ongoing depression, emotional numbness, fear, anger issues, chronic disease, or addiction it is important to seek help for yourself. Even on a subconscious level these traumas can be sabotaging our lives.
The practice of Bhakti yoga can be of immense help in overcoming trauma. Many therapists recommend yoga, meditation and mindfulness. If, despite our spiritual practice, the above symptoms remain, professional counselling can help. Along with the process of bhakti yoga, counselling can give meaning to the past and help us develop healthy behaviors, which when practiced, form new neurological pathways that guide us to beneficial responses which are no longer overridden by paste negative experiences.
As Srila Prabhupada says in BG 14.10 "But if one wants, he can develop, by practice, the mode of goodness and thus defeat the modes of ignorance and passion."
By playing our cards appropriately, we can transform an ACE into an opportunity for growth. Partha dasa is one of the founding members of the Grihastha Vision Team. Together with Uttama dasi, his wife for over 50 years, they have been serving the Vaishnava community by offering couple to couple premarital and marital education and by presenting seminars internationally since 2005.

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https://vaisnavafamilyresources.org/en/resources/domestic-abuse/

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1 Mental Health defined https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/mental-health-strengthening-our-response

2 Mental Distress defined https://dictionary.apa.org/psychological-distress

3 Mental Illness defined https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/publications/chronic-illness-mental-health

4 Types of stigma https://www.psychiatry.org/patients-families/stigma-and-discrimination

5 Mental illness is nothing to be ashamed off https://www.psychiatry.org/patients-families/what-is-mental-illness

6 "Material happiness and distress come as soon as we accept a material body, regardless of what form. We cannot avoid such happiness and distress under any circumstances." (SB 7.6.3) https://vedabase.io/en/library/sb/7/6/3/

7 How common is mental illness in the world https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/mental-disorders

8 Citi Sakti devi dasi – Overcoming Mental Health Challenges in spiritual life https://www.facebook.com/watch/live/?ref=watch_permalink&v=568566497358261

9 "After many births and deaths, he who is actually in knowledge surrenders unto Me, knowing Me to be the cause of all causes and all that is. Such a great soul is very rare." https://vedabase.io/en/library/bg/7/19/

10 "The root cause of devotional service to Lord Kṛṣṇa is association with advanced devotees. Even when one's dormant love for Kṛṣṇa awakens, association with devotees is still most essential. CC Madhya Lila 22.83 https://vedabase.io/en/library/cc/madhya/22/83/

11 "The material miseries of the living entity, which are superfluous to him, can be directly mitigated by the linking process of devotional service. But the mass of people do not know this, and therefore the learned Vyāsadeva compiled this Vedic literature, which is in relation to the Supreme Truth." (SB 1.7.6) https://vedabase.io/en/library/sb/1/7/6/

12 "When advancement of knowledge is applied in the service of the Lord, the whole process becomes absolute. The Personality of Godhead and His transcendental name, fame, glory, etc., are all nondifferent from Him. Therefore, all the sages and devotees of the Lord have recommended that the subject matter of art, science, philosophy, physics, chemistry, psychology and all other branches of knowledge should be wholly and solely applied in the service of the Lord... All "knowledge" not engaged in the service of the Lord is but nescience. Real utilization of advanced knowledge is to establish the glories of the Lord, and that is the real import.

Scientific knowledge engaged in the service of the Lord, and all similar activities, are all factually hari-kīrtana, or glorification of the Lord. (SB 1.5.22) https://vedabase.io/en/library/sb/1/5/22/

13 "You ask if children may be taken to ordinary medical doctors. Why not? Of course, we do not always trust that these doctors may be doing the right thing, but what can be done? The governing principle for our activity should be to do what is favourable for pleasing Krishna. So, if your child requires medical attention to be fit for serving Krishna, then it is only practical she should get it."(Letter to Lalita Kumar and Jambavati -- Vrindaban 27 November, 1971)

14 Forgetful men do not know the right path for peace and prosperity. However, the sages know it well, and therefore for the good of all men they are always anxious to perform acts which may bring about peace in the world. They are sincere friends to all living entities, and at the risk of great personal inconvenience they are always engaged in the service of the Lord for the good of all people. SB 1.1.4 purport] https://vedabase.io/en/library/sb/1/1/4/

15 "Offering gifts in charity, accepting charitable gifts, revealing one's mind in confidence, inquiring confidentially, accepting prasāda and offering prasāda are the six symptoms of love shared by one devotee and another." Nectar of Instruction Verse 4 https://vedabase.io/en/library/noi/4/

16 The offenses against chanting the holy name are as follows: i) To blaspheme the devotees who have dedicated their lives for propagating the holy name of the Lord.ii) To consider the names of the demigods like Lord Siva or Lord Brahma to be equal to, or independent of, the name Lord Vishnu. iii) To disobey the orders of the spiritual master. iv) To blaspheme the Vedic literature or literature in pursuance of the Vedic version. v) To consider the glories of chanting Hare Krishna to be imagination. vi) To give some interpretation on the holy name of the Lord. vii) To commit sinful activities on the strength of chanting the holy name of the Lord. viii) To consider chanting of Hare Krishna one of the auspicious ritualistic activities offered in the Vedas as fruitive activities (karma-kanda). ix) To instruct a faithless person about the glories of the holy name. x) To not have complete faith in the chanting of the holy names and to maintain material attachments, even after understanding so many instructions on this matter.

17 "The Supreme Lord is situated in everyone's heart, O Arjuna, and is directing the wanderings of all living entities, who are seated as on a machine, made of the material energy." (BG 18.61) https://vedabase.io/en/library/bg/18/61/

18 7 Seven Purposes of ISKCON: https://prabhupada.io/wiki/7_purposes_of_iskcon

19 Crawford, Tanya & Lipsedge, Maurice. (2004). Seeking help for psychological distress: The interface of Zulu traditional healing and Western biomedicine.

20 The mind is the root cause of lust, anger, pride, greed, lamentation, illusion and fear. Combined, these constitute bondage to fruitive activity. What learned man would put faith in the mind? SB 5.6.5 https://vedabase.io/en/library/sb/5/6/5/

21 Depression is real https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/depression

22 W Sinnott-Armstrong, H Pickard - The Oxford Handbook of Philosophy and Psychiatry

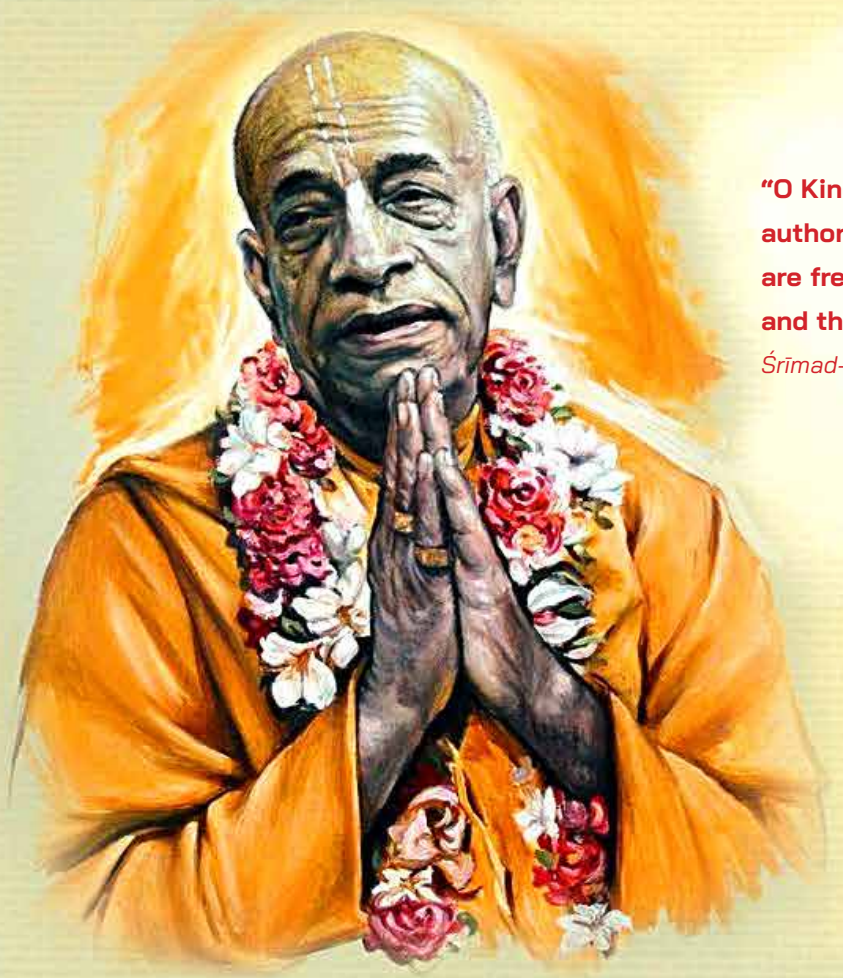
23 Semaille P. [The new types of addiction] Revue Medicale de Bruxelles. 2009 Sep;30(4):335-357. PMID: 19899381.

24 Bruce K. Alexander (2000) The Globalization of Addiction, Addiction Research

25 "As for detachment from children, wife and home, it is not meant that one should have no feeling for these. They are natural objects of affection. But when they are not favorable to spiritual progress, then one should not be attached to them." [BG 13.8-12, purport] https://vedabase.io/en/library/bg/13/8-12/

26 Transaltion: "When Dhruva Mahārāja heard of the killing of his brother Uttama by the Yakṣas in the Himālaya Mountains, being overwhelmed with lamentation and anger, he got on his chariot and went out for victory over the city of the Yakṣas, Alakāpurī." Purport: Dhruva Mahārāja's becoming angry, overwhelmed with grief, and envious of the enemies was not incompatible with his position as a great devotee. It is a misunderstanding that a devotee should not be angry, envious or overwhelmed by lamentation. Dhruva Mahārāja was the king, and when his brother was unceremoniously killed, it was his duty to take revenge against the Yakṣas from the Himālayas. [SB 4.10.4] https://vedabase.io/en/library/sb/4/10/4/





"O King, constant chanting of the holy name of the Lord after the ways of the great authorities is the doubtless and fearless way of success for all, including those who are free from all material desires, those who are desirous of all material enjoyment, and those who are self-satisfied by dint of transcendental knowledge."

Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam (SB 2.1.11)

HARE KRISHNA HARE KRISHNA
KRISHNA KRISHNA HARE HARE
HARE RAMA HARE RAMA
RAMA RAMA HARE HARE